

UPDATED BC Seaweed Sector & Workforce SWOT Analysis – TOP Priorities (June 21, 2022)

#1 (4 votes); #2 (3 votes)

STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
<u>Sector Strengths:</u> • 1 - Fosters reconciliation – value-led practices – emerging FN partnerships and FN support; leverage UNDRIP and DRIPA • 1 - Increasingly attractive to young people – green, carbon reducing and cool • 1 - Existing transferable skills from rest of aquaculture and food processing • First Nations workforce supply (higher growth rate of youth cohort and experience on the water and rural) in and close to seaweed farms • 2 - Massive BC coastline to draw upon – geographic advantage and ability to grow kelp • 2 - Academic involvement in research and development	<u>Sector Weaknesses:</u> • 1 - Broken regulatory process, tenure regulations, licensing timelines; arbitrary rules; risking growth of the sector • 1 - Access to capital – Investors are focused on do you have a market and how do you get there • 1 - Capital returns are lengthy – government support needed, but there is a lack of government investment funding (see Europe and elsewhere in which government contributes millions and billions to seaweed) • 1 - Distributed workforce in small communities • 1 - Remote, farm, outdoor work may not be perceived as desirable • 2 - Limited processing infrastructure; few with food processing experience • 2 - Broader labour gap across most sectors – increased competition
OPPORTUNITIES	THREATS
<u>Sector Opportunities:</u> • 1 - New uses of seaweed (e.g., as a medical injectable, biostimulants, pet foods, herring and roe combination, etc.) • 2 - Food production and security • 2 - Transferable Skills – Research, Labour, Management, Policy, Sales, Marketing, Operations Management, QA and Food Safety, Logistics & Warehousing, Freight • 2 - Seafood/Food processing experience in BC – leverage processing capabilities and infrastructure – adapt and modify • 2 - All the insitutions on education and training institutions on Vancouver Island are willing and able to develop programs around kelp farming	<u>Sector Threats:</u> • 1 - DFO conditions of Licenses & Fees may change and other arbitrary regulatory actions • 1 - Licensing timelines are threatening sector growth and challenging with First Nation partners • 1 - Science gaps (e.g., genetic interactions – Cultivated vs. Wild and impacts on the ecosystem, seaweed carbon sequestration); governments should be doing the research • 2 - Species at Risk Act (e.g., Abalone) – cannot harm alter or anything in these areas; need a signal that the Act will be part of this process – prevent last minutes surprises • 2 - Uncertain seed supply • 2 - Lack of seasonal / part time labour supply (Harvesting & Processing) • 2 - Living costs / living standards in remote communities / interest rates impacting personal debt / affordability

